

Hands-on Lab: Getting Started with Branches using Git Commands



Estimated time needed: 25 minutes

Objectives

After completing this lab, you will be able to use git commands to work with branches on a local repository, including:

1. Create a new local repository using `git init`
2. Create and add a file to the repo using `git add`
3. Commit changes using `git commit`
4. Create a branch using `git branch`
5. Switch to a branch using `git checkout`
6. Check the status of files changed using `git status`
7. Review recent commits using `git log`
8. Revert changes using `git revert`
9. Get a list of branches and active branches using `git branch`
10. Merge changes in your active branch into another branch using `git merge`

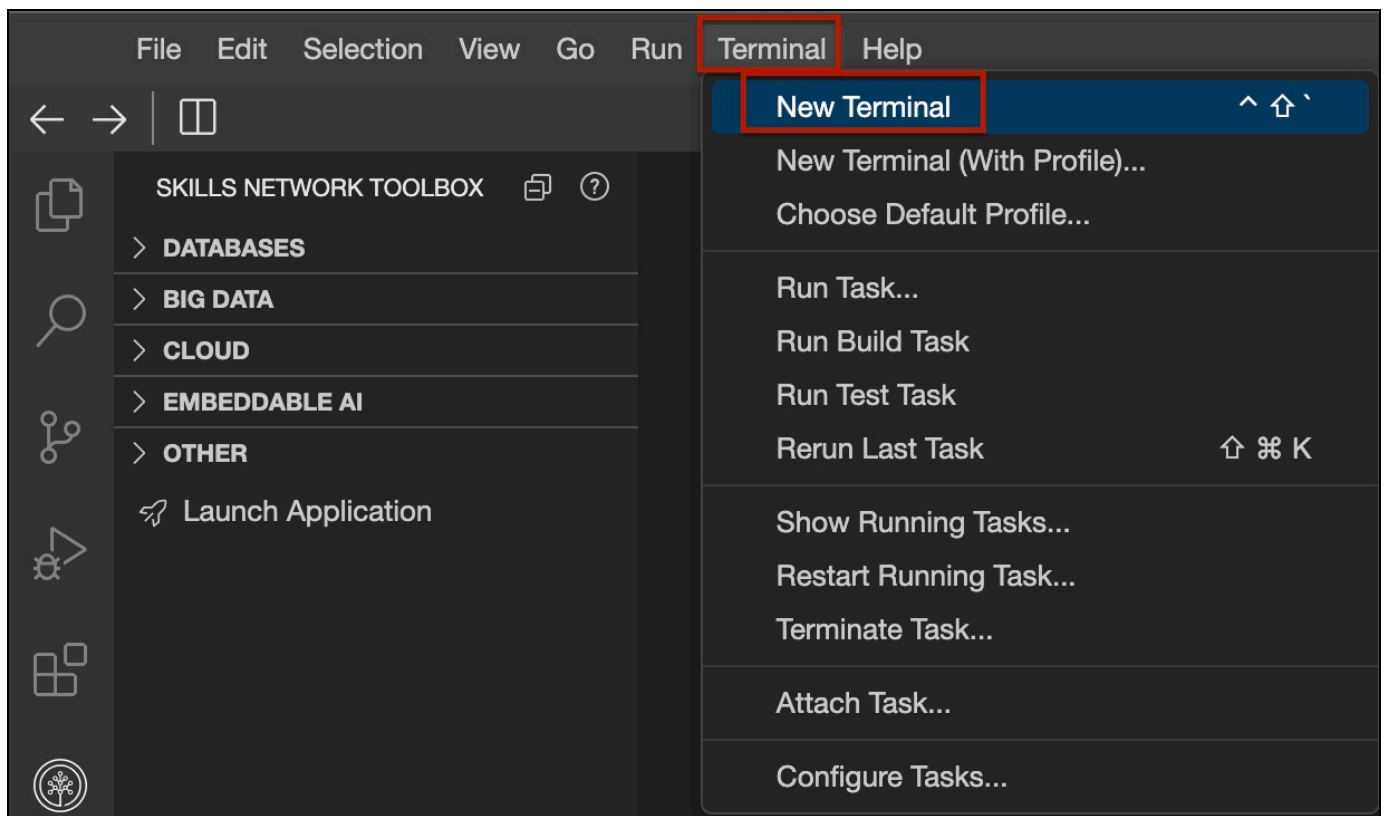
Pre-requisites

This lab is designed to be run on Skills Network, Cloud IDE that runs on a Linux system in the cloud and already has git installed. If you intend to run this lab on your own system, please ensure you have git (on Linux or MacOS) or Git Bash (on Windows) installed. Please check if you are using valid credentials and make sure you have a stable internet connection and a supported browser. In case of any issues, please consider clearing cache/cookies and retry.

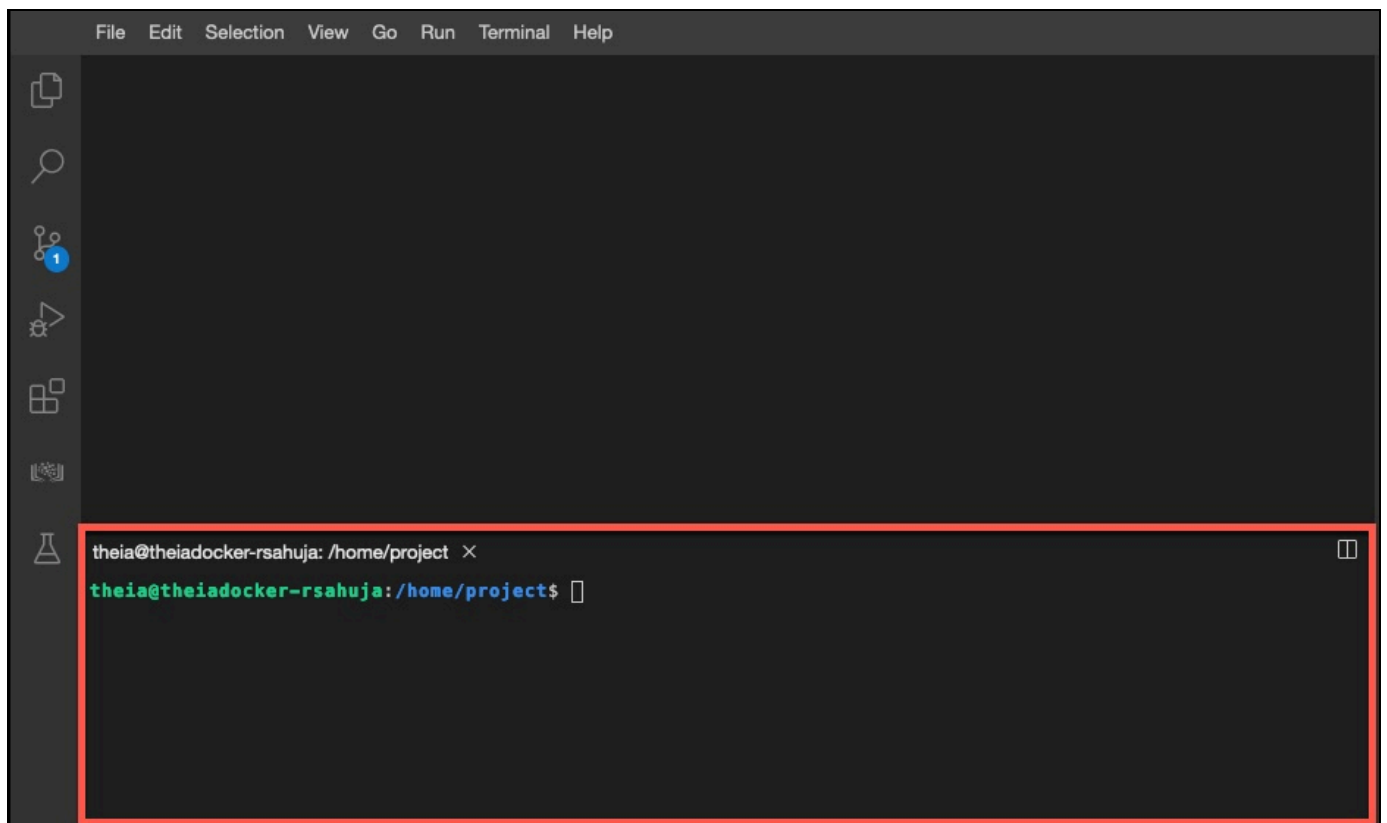
Initialize: Open a new terminal window

Open a terminal window in your IDE where you can start entering your shell and Git commands.

1. Click on the Terminal menu to the right of this instructions pane and then click on New Terminal.



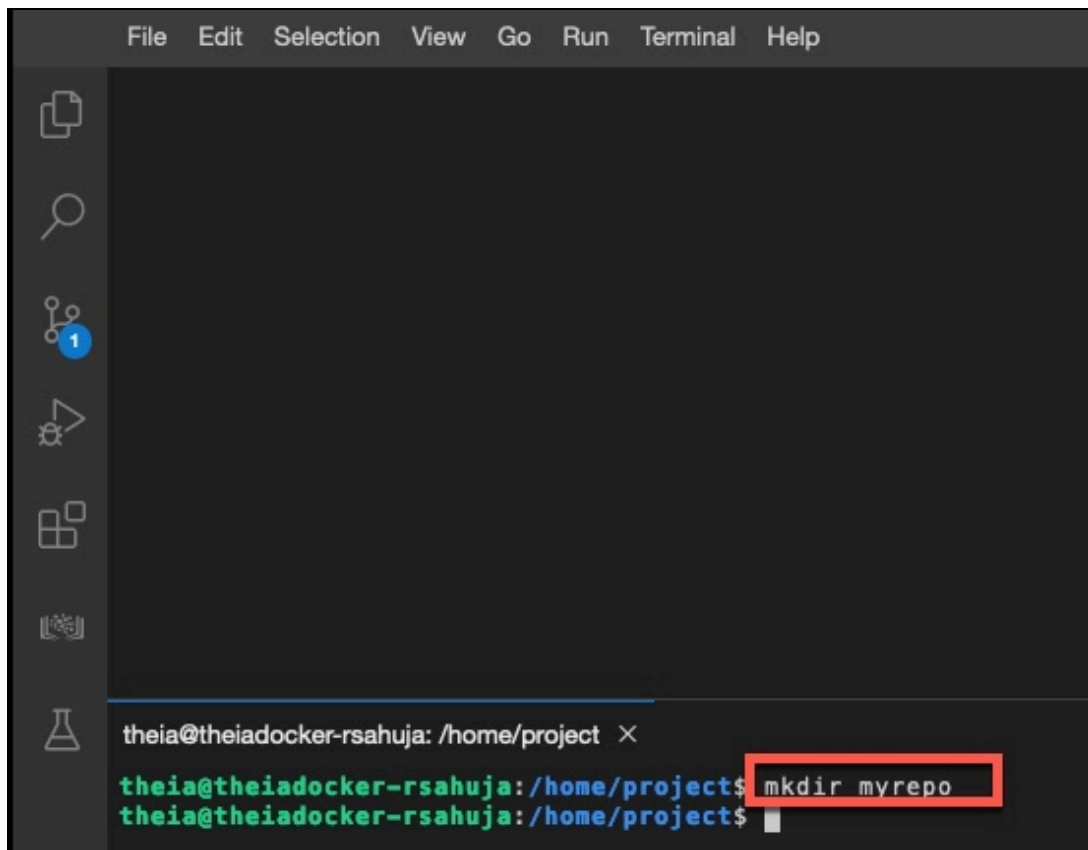
2. This will add a new terminal window at the bottom where you can start entering commands.



Exercise 1: Create a new local repo

1. Create a myrepo directory by running the `mkdir` command given below in the terminal.

```
mkdir myrepo
```



2. Go into the myrepo directory by running the following command.

```
cd myrepo
```

3. Initiate the myrepo directory as a git repository by using the `git init` command.

```
git init
```

4. A local git repository is now initiated with a `.git` folder containing all the git files, which you can verify by doing a directory listing by running the following command into the terminal window. The `.` prefix will make the git directory hidden. The `-la` option renders a long list, including the access permission, time of creation and other details for all the files in the hidden git directory.

```
ls -la .git
```

The output shows the contents of the `.git` sub-directory which contains all the information required by git server.

```
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja: /home/project/myrepo X
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project$ mkdir myrepo
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project$ cd myrepo
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git init
Initialized empty Git repository in /home/project/myrepo/.git/
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ ls -la .git
total 40
drwxr-sr-x 7 theia users 4096 Jan 15 01:53 .
drwxr-sr-x 3 theia users 4096 Jan 15 01:53 ..
drwxr-sr-x 2 theia users 4096 Jan 15 01:53 branches
-rw-r--r-- 1 theia users  92 Jan 15 01:53 config
-rw-r--r-- 1 theia users  73 Jan 15 01:53 description
-rw-r--r-- 1 theia users  23 Jan 15 01:53 HEAD
drwxr-sr-x 2 theia users 4096 Jan 15 01:53 hooks
drwxr-sr-x 2 theia users 4096 Jan 15 01:53 info
drwxr-sr-x 4 theia users 4096 Jan 15 01:53 objects
drwxr-sr-x 4 theia users 4096 Jan 15 01:53 refs
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$
```

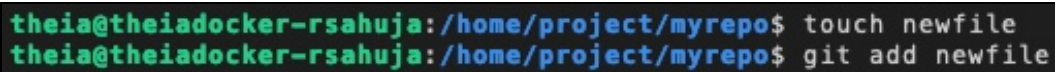
Exercise 2: Create and add a file to the local repo

1. Now create an empty file named newfile using the following touch command.

```
touch newfile
```

2. Add this file to the repo use the following git add command.

```
git add newfile
```

A terminal window with a dark background and green text. It shows two lines of commands being executed in a directory /home/project/myrepo. The first line is 'touch newfile' and the second line is 'git add newfile'. Both lines show the prompt 'theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:'.

```
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ touch newfile  
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git add newfile
```

Exercise 3: Commit changes

1. Before you commit the changes, you need to tell Git who you are. You can do this using the following commands. Replace "you@example.com" with the email address you use to login to GitHub. Replace **Your Name** with your name.

Please note the email and name have to be within quotes.

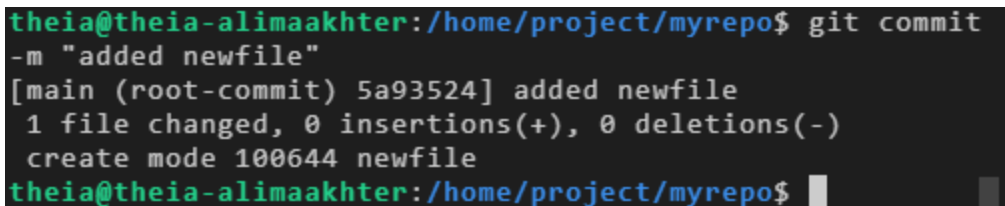
```
git config --global user.email "you@example.com"
```

```
git config --global user.name "Your Name"
```

2. You can now commit your changes using the following `git commit` command.

Note that the commit requires a message, which you can include using the `-m` parameter.

```
git commit -m "added newfile"
```

A terminal window with a dark background. The prompt is 'theia@theia-alimaakhter:/home/project/myrepo\$'. The user enters 'git commit -m "added newfile"'. The output shows the commit hash '5a93524', the message 'added newfile', and statistics: '1 file changed, 0 insertions(+), 0 deletions(-)'. It also shows 'create mode 100644 newfile'. The prompt returns to 'theia@theia-alimaakhter:/home/project/myrepo\$' with a cursor.

```
theia@theia-alimaakhter:/home/project/myrepo$ git commit
-m "added newfile"
[main (root-commit) 5a93524] added newfile
 1 file changed, 0 insertions(+), 0 deletions(-)
 create mode 100644 newfile
theia@theia-alimaakhter:/home/project/myrepo$
```

Exercise 4: Create a branch

1. Your previous commit created a default main branch called `main`.
2. To make subsequent changes in your repository, create a new branch in your local repository. Run the following `git branch` command into the terminal to create a branch called `my1stbranch`.

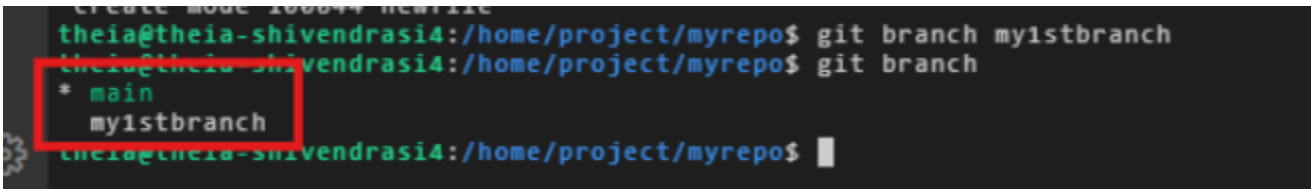
```
git branch my1stbranch
```

Exercise 5: Get a list of branches and active branch

1. Check the list of branches your repository contains by running the following `git branch` command.

```
git branch
```

2. Note that the output lists two branches: The default `main` branch with an asterisk `*` next to it indicating that it is the currently active branch and the newly created `my1stbranch`.

A terminal window screenshot showing the execution of the 'git branch' command. The prompt is 'theia@theia-shivendras14:/home/project/myrepo\$'. The command 'git branch' is entered, and the output is displayed: '* main' and 'my1stbranch'. The output is highlighted with a red rectangular box.

```
theia@theia-shivendras14:/home/project/myrepo$ git branch my1stbranch
theia@theia-shivendras14:/home/project/myrepo$ git branch
* main
my1stbranch
theia@theia-shivendras14:/home/project/myrepo$
```

Exercise 6: Switch to a different branch

1. Since you now want to work in the new branch to make your changes, run the following `git checkout` command to make it the active branch.

```
git checkout my1stbranch
```

2. Verify that the new branch is now the active branch by running the following `git branch` command.

```
git branch
```

3. Note that the asterisk * is now next to the my1stbranch, indicating that it is now active.

```
theia@theia-shivendras14:/home/project/myrepo$ git branch my1stbranch
theia@theia-shivendras14:/home/project/myrepo$ git branch
* main
  my1stbranch
theia@theia-shivendras14:/home/project/myrepo$ git checkout my1stbranch
Switched to branch 'my1stbranch'
theia@theia-shivendras14:/home/project/myrepo$ git branch
  main
* my1stbranch
theia@theia-shivendras14:/home/project/myrepo$
```

As a shortcut, instead of creating a branch using `git branch` and then making it active using `git checkout`, you can use the `git checkout` command followed by the `-b` option, that creates the branch and makes it active in one step.

```
git checkout -b my1stbranch
```

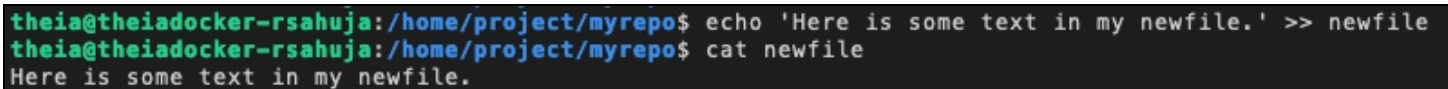
Exercise 7: Make changes in your branch and check the status of files added or changed

1. Make some changes to your new branch, called my1stbranch. Start by adding some text to newfile by running the following command into the terminal that will append the string "Here is some text in my newfile." into the file.

```
echo 'Here is some text in my newfile.' >> newfile
```


2. Verify the text has been added by running the following `cat` command.

```
cat newfile
```

A terminal window with a dark background. The prompt is 'theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo\$'. The first command is 'echo 'Here is some text in my newfile.' >> newfile'. The second command is 'cat newfile'. The output of the second command is 'Here is some text in my newfile.'

```
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ echo 'Here is some text in my newfile.' >> newfile
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ cat newfile
Here is some text in my newfile.
```

3. Now, create another file called `readme.md` using the following command.

```
touch readme.md
```

4. And now, add it to the repo with the following `git add` command.

```
git add readme.md
```

5. So far, in your new branch, you have edited the `newfile` and added a file called `readme.md`. You can easily verify the changes in your current branch using the `git status` command.

```
git status
```

6. The output of the `git status` command shows that the file `readme.md` has been added to the branch and is ready to be committed since you added it to the branch using `git add`. However, even though you modified the file called `newfile` you did not explicitly add it using `git add`, and hence it is not ready to be committed.

```
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ touch readme.md
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git add readme.md
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git status
On branch mv1stbranch
Changes to be committed:
  (use "git reset HEAD <file>..." to unstage)

    new file:   readme.md

Changes not staged for commit:
  (use "git add <file>..." to update what will be committed)
  (use "git checkout -- <file>..." to discard changes in working directory)

    modified:   newfile
```

7. A shortcut to adding all modifications and additions is to use the following `git add` command with an asterisk `*`. This will also add the modified file `newfile` to the branch and make it ready to be committed.

```
git add *
```

8. Let's check the status again.

```
git status
```

9. The output now shows that both the files can now be committed.

```
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git add *
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git status
On branch my1stbranch
Changes to be committed:
  (use "git reset HEAD <file>..." to unstage)

        modified:   newfile
        new file:   readme.md
```

Exercise 8: Commit and review commit history

1. Now that your changes are ready, you can save them to the branch using the following commit command with a message indicating the changes.

```
git commit -m "added readme.md modified newfile"
```

2. We can run the following `git log` command to get a history of recent commits:

```
git log
```

3. The log shows two recent commits: The last commit to `my1stbranch` as well as the previous commit to `main`.

```
theia@theia-shivendrasia4:/home/project/myrepo$ git log
commit 393aee4e1327e9f8506e80d02014d021431e848f (HEAD -> my1stbranch)
Author: Shivendra Sinha <shivendrasinha60@gmail.com>
Date: Tue Aug 19 05:32:33 2025 -0400

    added readme.md modified newfile

commit 8bd5b3c47ff22907e4654ec9a31f7bb88cfe248f (main)
Author: Shivendra Sinha <shivendrasinha60@gmail.com>
Date: Tue Aug 19 05:27:19 2025 -0400

    added newfile

o (Git) - my1stbranch theia@theia-shivendrasia4:/home/project/myrepo$ ||
```

Note: To exit the `git log` command, simply press the "Q" key. This action will close the log view and bring you back to the command prompt.

Exercise 9: Revert committed changes

1. Sometimes, you may not fully test your changes before committing them, which may have undesirable consequences. You can back out your changes by using a `git revert` command like the following.

You can either specify the ID of your commit that you can see from the previous log output or use the shortcut `HEAD` to rollback the last commit:

```
git revert HEAD --no-edit
```

NOTE: 1. If you don't specify the `--no-edit` flag, you may be presented with an editor screen showing the message with changes to be reverted. In that case, press the `Control` (or `Ctrl`) key simultaneously with `x`.

2. `git revert HEAD` **does not delete a file**, it **adds a new commit** that undoes the changes introduced by the previous commit.

2. The output shows the most recent commit with the specified id has been reverted.

```
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git revert HEAD --no-edit
[my1stbranch f4f5600] Revert "modified newfile added readme.md"
Date: Sat Jan 15 04:39:38 2022 +0000
2 files changed, 1 deletion(-)
delete mode 100644 readme.md
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$
```

Exercise 10: Merge changes into another branch

1. Let's make one more change in your currently active `my1stbranch` using the following commands.

```
touch goodfile
git add goodfile
```

```
git commit -m "added goodfile"  
git log
```

2. The output of the log shows the newly added goodfile has been committed to the my1stbranch branch:

```
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git status  
On branch my1stbranch  
nothing to commit, working tree clean  
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ touch goodfile  
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git add goodfile  
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git commit -m "added goodfile"  
[my1stbranch d8680b4] added goodfile  
1 file changed, 0 insertions(+), 0 deletions(-)  
create mode 100644 goodfile  
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git log  
commit d8680b4cf63ff3e97b2970704806c14dc6134dd1 (HEAD -> my1stbranch)  
Author: Your Name <you@example.com>  
Date: Sat Jan 15 04:53:27 2022 +0000  
  
    added goodfile
```

Note: To exit the `git log` command, simply press the "Q" key. This action will close the log view and bring you back to the command prompt.

3. Now, let's merge the contents of the my1stbranch into the main branch. We will first need to make the main branch active using the following `git checkout` command.

```
git checkout main
```

4. Now, let's merge the changes from my1stbranch into master.

```
git merge my1stbranch  
git log
```

5. Output and log shows the successful merging of the branch.

```
Updating 8bd5b3c..7c5dd82
Fast-forward
 goodfile | 0
1 file changed, 0 insertions(+), 0 deletions(-)
create mode 100644 goodfile
commit 7c5dd823c311d4966e940228ead7724651e99f25 (HEAD -> main, my1stbranch)
Author: Shivendra Sinha <shivendrasinha60@gmail.com>
Date: Tue Aug 19 05:34:41 2025 -0400

    added goodfile

commit d208320397d3575e50a0efd49ca6e27dd866677f
```

6. Now that changes have been merged into main branch, the my1stbranch can be deleted using the following git branch command with the -d option:

```
git branch -d my1stbranch
```

```
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$ git branch -d my1stbranch
Deleted branch my1stbranch (was d8680b4).
theia@theiadocker-rsahuja:/home/project/myrepo$
```

Exercise 11: Practice on your own

1. Create a new directory and branch called newbranch
2. Make newbranch the active branch
3. Create an empty file called newbranchfile
4. Add the newly created file to your branch
5. Commit the changes in your newbranch
6. Revert the last committed changes
7. Create a new file called newgoodfile
8. Add the latest file to newbranch
9. Commit the changes
10. Merge the changes in newbranch into main

Summary

In this lab, you have learned how to create and work with branches using Git commands in a local repository. In a subsequent lab, you will learn how to synchronize changes in your local repository with remote GitHub

repositories.

Author(s)

Rav Ahuja

Other Contributor(s)

Richard Ye

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